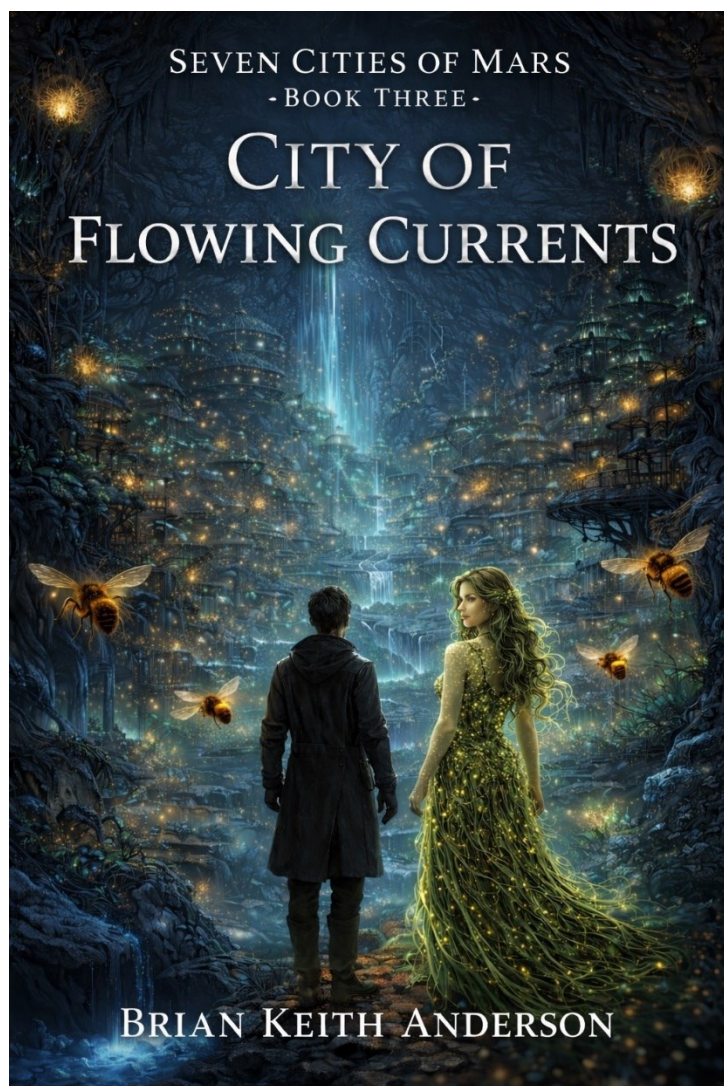




The City of Flowing Currents

Seven Cities of Mars — Book Three

by

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Series Page

The Seven Cities of Mars

Book One — *The City of Enduring Light*

Book Two — *The City of Silence*

Book Three — *The City of Flowing
Currents*

Dedication

For those who have learned to listen,
and now are ready to move.

Epigraph

Life does not remain still.

It finds its way.

And in its movement,

it remembers what it is.

Movement does not begin with force.

It begins with allowance.

What is still must first learn to listen.

What listens must then learn to trust.

Only then does life begin to move

again—

not as it was,

but as it must become.

Chapter One — The First Movement

The ground did not tremble.

It shifted.

Not in any way Asa could name at first—
not a break, not a rise. Something beneath
the surface had begun to move, and the
movement carried upward through the
stone until it reached him. He felt it
through the soles of his boots before he
saw anything change.

He stood still, listening.

The silence he had learned within the last city did not leave him. It remained, held close, steady as breath. But this was not that same stillness. This was something within it—something that did not rest.

A faint line of light traced along the rock ahead. It did not flare or pulse. It flowed, thin as a thread, slipping between cracks that had not been there moments before.

Saxifraga had already turned toward it.

She did not speak. She did not need to.

The shift had reached her before it
reached him. He could see it in the way
she held herself—alert, but not wary. As
if she recognized what was coming,
though she had not yet named it.

Asa stepped forward.

The light did not retreat. It moved.

Not away from him—past him.

He paused, letting it pass, watching the
way it carried itself through the stone. It
did not break through. It found its path,

slipping along unseen channels, turning
where the ground allowed it.

“Not force,” he said quietly.

The words felt right, though he did not
know why.

Saxifraga inclined her head, only slightly.
Agreement, or perhaps acknowledgment.

The line of light widened.

It gathered where the stone dipped,
drawing into a shallow hollow that had
not existed before. There, it slowed. Not
stopping—never stopping—but settling,

as water might settle when the ground
gave it room.

Asa crouched.

He did not reach for it. That instinct had
long since left him. Instead, he watched
the way it moved within itself, folding
and unfolding in patterns that did not
repeat.

It was not random.

It was not directed.

It was finding its way.

Behind him, the path they had taken no longer lay as it had. The surface had shifted—subtly, but enough that the route could not be traced back step for step.

What had been fixed was no longer fixed.

He straightened.

“We can’t follow what we remember,” he said.

Saxifraga looked past him, toward the darkened passage that had brought them here. For a moment she seemed to listen—not to the silence, but to what moved within it.

Then she turned back to the light.

“No,” she said.

It was the first word she had spoken since they entered this place.

The sound of it did not disturb the movement. It passed through it, as easily as breath through air.

The hollow deepened.

Asa watched as the ground itself seemed to give way—not collapsing, not breaking, but opening. The light filled the

space as it formed, tracing new lines
outward from that center point.

More lines appeared.

Not from above.

From within.

They spread through the stone in quiet
patterns, crossing, dividing, joining again.

Each followed its own path, yet none
collided. Where they met, they did not
stop. They changed direction.

“Currents,” Asa said.

This time, he knew the word.

Saxifraga stepped forward, closer to the edge of the forming hollow. The light reflected faintly against her, though it did not cast shadow in the way Asa expected. It seemed to recognize her presence without altering its course.

She extended her hand—not to touch, but to feel.

The lines shifted.

Only slightly. Only enough that Asa noticed.

He did not move.

The instinct to act—to guide, to correct—
rose and fell within him without taking
hold. What he had learned in silence held
him steady now.

This was not something to shape.

This was something to follow.

The hollow opened further, revealing
depth where none had been. Within it, the
light gathered into streams, each one
carrying the same quiet motion, each one
finding its own way downward.

There was no single path.

There never would be.

Asa took another step, then another,
following the edge rather than the center.

The ground beneath him adjusted, not
resisting, not yielding—simply allowing.

He felt the movement again, stronger
now.

Not beneath him.

Around him.

The city was not waiting.

It had already begun.

Saxifraga moved ahead of him, her steps sure despite the shifting ground. She did not look back. She did not need to.

Asa followed.

The path did not exist until he walked it. And once he passed, it did not remain.

Ahead, the light deepened, widening into channels that curved out of sight. The air carried a faint change—cooler, touched with something he could not name but recognized all the same.

Life.

Not as it had been.

Not as he had known it.

But moving.

Always moving.

He did not try to understand it.

Not yet.

For now, it was enough to walk, to watch,
and to let the current carry what it would.

And for the first time since leaving the
silence behind, Asa did not look for
stillness.

He listened for movement.